

6N Sunday, April 12, 2015

Classified

Injured hawk released to the wild

[from IN]

ters honored Bird's new freedom after the release by hosting a brewing demonstration and drinking craft beers.

The last time Johnson had seen the Raptor Center release a bird was at the Brewmasters' 2011 Oktoberfest. Johnson was the festival director and the Brewmasters donated \$20,000. Last year, the Brewmasters partnered with the Raptor Center for one of its Thursday Night Flights fundraisers.

Bird's journey to good health began in August when Johnson noticed her two black Labrador mixes paying attention to something hopping around in her fenced-in backyard. Because of some previous connections through the Brewmasters, Johnson phoned the Carolina Raptor Center who sent an expert to retrieve it.

The following day, Johnson called the Raptor Center to check on its status and was told it had a broken wing. From that moment, Bird became patient 18201 and Johnson was able to track the hawk's progress through the Raptor Center's website.

The Raptor Center tends to a thousand raptors a year, more than any raptor center in the country, according to Miller Houck, the center's associate executive director. The center releases about 500 birds to nature each year.

"This is my favorite part of the job," said Miller Houck. "It's a culmination of the hard work of the hospital staff and the volunteers."

During its rehabilitation, Bird suffered a broken foot, which required surgery and the insertion of a pin that was later removed. It slowed the rehab process and delayed Bird's re-



COURTESY OF TOM HENDERSON PHOTOGRAPHY LLC

Lisa Johnson, left, and Michele Miller Houck, associate executive director at The Carolina Raptor Center, release a broad-winged hawk into nature.



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But Bird's injuries weren't the only hold up to his return to the wild. Miller Houck explained that broad-winged hawks are migratory birds and normally fly south for the winter. By the time his injuries healed, all of Bird's friends had left for Florida.

In the final month before his release, Bird was confined to a flight cage - his 12-foot tall, 12-foot wide, and 50-foot long home in which he could stretch his wings and get acclimated to flight.

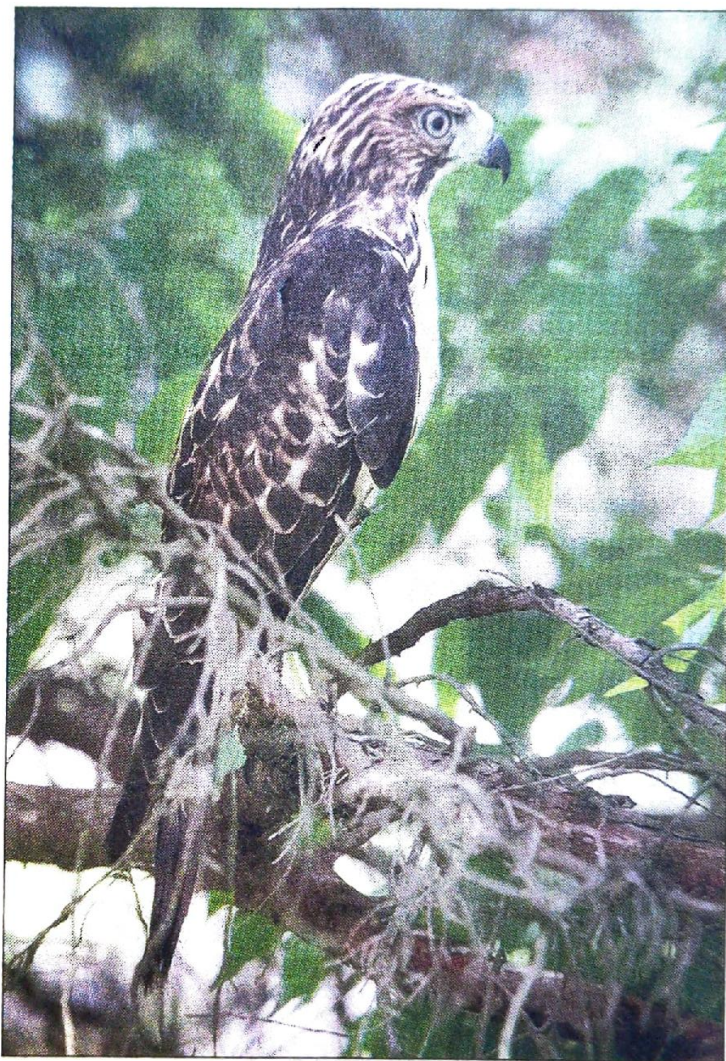
About a week prior to the release, Johnson decided to invite her friends, fellow Brewmaster members and her Walnut Creek neighbors to the event. One of those looking forward to it was neighbor Caitlin Williams, 10, who aspires to be a veterinarian.

One of the ways the Brewmasters collected money for the Raptor Cen-



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ter was through a 50/50 raffle. Caitlin's grandmother Janice Crum bought her the winning ticket.

Caitlin donated half of it, \$77, to the Raptor Center, per her grandmother's encouragement. Caitlin says she's saving the other half for a trip she's taking with her Palisades Park Elementary school classmates to Charleston.

By the time Bird arrived, someone had already played a loop of bird-themed songs on an iPod and a set of speakers: Steve Miller's "Fly Like an

Eagle," the Beatles' "Blackbird" and "Surfin Bird" by Big Bird, also known as the "Bird is the Word" song.

Moments before the release, Johnson announced that Bird's name was being changed and that it would share a moniker with another appropriate song for the day: Freebird.

>> Joe Habina is a freelance writer. Have a story idea for Joe? Email him at joehabina@gmail.com.